

Global South Women in STEM (GSW-STEM): Founding Manifesto

Why we exist

Humanity is entering a new technological era. Artificial intelligence, advanced computing, biotechnology, and new digital infrastructures are changing how societies function and how power is distributed. Yet a large share of the world's population still has no internet access, has never used a computer, or faces educational gaps that keep them from even understanding the language of technology.

Technology shapes economies, security, knowledge production, and political power. Those who do not take part in creating it will remain dependent on those who do.

Women have historically been excluded from the hard sciences and technological development, and we remain underrepresented in the fields defining the next global transformation. The gap is deeper in the Global South, where structural inequalities limit access to high-level education, research infrastructure, and technological production. Inclusion cannot rely on affirmative policies alone. It requires coordinated, intentional, long-term action led by the women who live these realities.

Who we are

GSW-STEM is a network of institutions and individuals working in and around technology: data and software engineers, computer and data scientists, researchers, designers, artists and creatives working with technology, journalists and communicators, entrepreneurs, CEOs of private and nonprofit initiatives, educators, and policymakers. Brazil, Uganda, Cameroon, South Africa, India, and Ethiopia are already part of it.

We are not a charity, a traditional NGO, or a conventional company. We are a **social enterprise network**, a different kind of institution. Each member keeps her own organization, context, and stakeholders. Together we pool expertise, contacts, and credibility to do what none of us could do alone. Leadership is shared: any member can propose a project, bring in funding, and carry it out in the name of the network, with the support of the others.

What we believe

Women as leaders, not only beneficiaries. Many Global South women are already trained, already specialized, and already leading initiatives. What is missing is that they be recognized as leaders and heard where technological futures are decided. We exist to put them in those rooms.

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Our problems are specific, and often shared. Unreliable infrastructure, limited connectivity, and local educational and economic realities shape technology in our countries. A problem in Ethiopia may be the same one in Brazil or India. By connecting across borders, we build solutions together and seek funding together.

STEM goes beyond code. Many women in the Global South do not need only to learn Python or AI. They need technology applied to their own work: agriculture, energy, health, biotechnology, and business. We embrace agritech, biotech, energy, and every field where science and technology can change livelihoods.

Impact is measured in real communities. Every project we support must name the specific community it serves, such as smallholder farmers or underserved rural women, and explain how it will reach them. “Technology for social good” is not enough. Because we focus on vulnerable communities, our work will also benefit men, boys, and children, and we recognize that young men in disadvantaged contexts also deserve opportunity. Our central mission and leadership remain centered on women.

Knowledge belongs to the Global South. Our projects should leave behind public-domain knowledge, such as reports, lessons learned, and methods, that any Global South organization can adapt and reuse in its own country.

Sustainability and reciprocity. Women have long carried the work of care worldwide, often without return. We choose to care for our communities and for ourselves. The network will earn, reinvest, and grow so that it can pay its contributors and eventually fund education for other women. When our name, expertise, or labor create value, part of that value returns to the network. Financial sustainability is part of our foundation, not a later add-on. Details will be set out in our internal policies.

Boundaries and clarity. Our time and energy are limited, so we choose partners deliberately. We welcome partnerships, but we are clear about who profits and what the network receives in exchange. Our name is not lent to initiatives that profit from it without benefiting the network and its members.

Commitment and action. A network lives through its members’ work. Every member commits real time to the network’s projects, even if it is just one or two hours a week, and shares responsibility for what we promise. We promise only what we can deliver. Members who remain inactive over time may step back from active membership.

How we start

We begin small and practical, so that we build through action rather than ambition alone:

1. **Support funding and grant applications.** We help members, and trusted people outside the network, polish and submit grant, startup, and fellowship proposals. Successful projects share a public-domain output and credit the network, and we may charge a service fee for consulting.
2. **Make visible what we do.** We publish our members’ work, results, and projects.

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3. **Run events.** We organize events, including ticketed ones open to all genders, to build visibility and income, and to bring members and partners together, with London as a possible venue.
4. **Build partnerships with education, government, and industry.** We connect with universities, ministries, and companies that can offer funding, scholarships, training, and opportunities.
5. **Grow with intention.** We decide together how large the core group should be and whether we act mainly as a bridge to existing networks or build our own structure, so that we complement and do not duplicate the many networks already out there.

Our commitment

We are building more than a professional community. We are building the collective capacity of Global South women to shape the technological future of our societies, and to ensure that no one is left behind.

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